Technology in Social Contexts: Subjective Well-being in Young Adults

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The advent of technology in the 21st century has spread and solidified itself as a necessity in the modern age (Van Deursen, 2019; Yee et al., 2025; We Are Social et al., 2023). Various forms of technology, such as media, film, and video games, are utilized to replace in-person human socialization (Bethel et al., 2025; Choi et al., 2022; Wulf, Breuer, & Schmitt, 2022; Corey, 2026). This growth in social relations through technology in the past decades relates to both building and maintaining relationships to bolster wellbeing (Kraut et al., 1998; Dienlin & Johannes, 2020; Wu et al., 2016). Socialization through technology informs the values defined in culture and builds the foundation for values to evolve (Bethel et al. 2025; Choi et al. 2022). The changes in technology use for social relationships inform how younger generations interact with each other: unique dynamics such as parasocial relationships are being created by these technological changes (Masur, 2021; Xie et al., 2026). The dynamic between digital relationships and value discernment informs each other: technology becomes the medium through which emotions from these dynamics are fostered (Masur, 2021; Wulf, Breuer, & Schmitt, 2022). In this new technological environment of devices and AI, younger generations exposed to these tools inform their choice of values and subsequently, the actions and decisions they make in their lives as emerging adults (Gravelle et al., 2024). The constructs of technology, social connections, and subjective well-being are nuanced and complex; each of these constructs plays a key role in informing and interacting with the other constructs in this review.

Technology

Technology use has intensified and broadened in recent years among college students (Rotunda et al., 2025). Media consumption for television content averages 5 hours a day in the United States: internet addiction and problematic internet use have grown as issues young adults face (We Are Social et al., 2023; Rotunda et al., 2025). Students report difficulty adapting to new

digital formats, such as shifting to new modes of learning during the COVID-19 pandemic (Gravelle et al., 2024; Van Deursen & Van Dijk, 2018). There exists an inequality in technology use and skills, measured by the differences in material access, frequency of internet use, and identifying insufficiencies in educational spaces (Van Deursen, 2019; Gnambs & Schwaß, 2025). Despite the large amount of financial investment into various technologies such as AI, digital trust, and sustainability, the potential social and economic impact remains undiscovered (Yee et al. 2025). Technology exists in many forms, and human interaction with these new tools focuses on digital socialization and social media for this study.

As technology use increases in use for a wide variety of fields such as sustainability, agriculture, and health, younger generations have the potential to guide the future of technology (United Nations, 2020). Other forms of technology used in adolescent and younger generations exist in the form of videos, images, and audio content that carry specific cultural references; the cultural references evoked greater arousal, valence, and feelings of relatedness in identity (Bethel et al., 2025). Video and television consumption are indicative of changing lifestyles of new technology, and media in the form of video and television have control over where attention is focused (Bethel et al. 2025; Choi et al. 2022). Longer time spent watching television correlates with lower levels of adolescent delinquency in youth, suggesting that both positive and negative implications of technology use in youth exist (Choi et al., 2022).

Amongst the changing uses of technology, video games have surged as a new form of modern entertainment with an interactive component that relates to adolescents' sense of well-being. Forms of interactive digital games, such as Exergaming, improved physical activity levels in children with Autism Spectrum Disorder (Corey, 2026). During the COVID-19 pandemic, adolescents utilized media in the form of video games to induce the feeling of

nostalgia due to fears of isolation (Wulf et al., 2022). During COVID-19, stressors, faltering well-being, and feelings of escapism rose as a result of social disconnect (Wulf et al., 2022). Technology is utilized mainly as a tool to interact with others, and embedded in the conversation of digitized relationships is the user's social connectedness. Careful consideration is necessary to assess future impact, as younger generations are utilizing and connecting emotionally through technology: regulations are integral to preventing harmful circumstances as they relate to data privacy, declining jobs due to automation, and a futuristic cyberspace (United Nations, 2020).

Social Connectedness

The context in which emerging adults utilize social media is important to consider. Social Media connects nearly half of the global population through this online digital medium (United Nations, 2020). In a self-report study on the effects of online communication, Dienlin & Johannes found that adolescents experienced a wide range of positive, neutral, and negative emotions when using social media (2020). When utilizing social media to distract, procrastinate, or avoid, adolescents reported negative effects in short-term well-being measures (Dienlin & Johannes, 2020; Wu et al., 2016). During the COVID-19 pandemic, social media use correlates with a positive sense of interconnectedness with peers, or a negative sense of loneliness and isolation (Dienlin & Johannes, 2020; Wu et al., 2016). People who engaged more in face-to-face interactions in the past are more likely to engage in online messaging platforms, which correlated with lower levels of loneliness (Dienlin, Masur, & Trepte, 2020). Kraut et al. argue that technology works in favor of helping people cull weak tie relationships by replacing them with stronger tie relationships; Valkenburg argues that online contacts are more superficial and less affectionate, creating a low quality of communication in relationships that may decrease levels of well-being (1998;2007).

A good quality of communication, defined in terms of affection, commitment, and authenticity, is important to consider as a mediator for the constructs of social media and loneliness (Dienlin, Masur, & Trepte, 2020; Valkenburg & Peter, 2007). Studies define the quality of communication as the mediator between technology and loneliness correlations, and others instead define frequency of time spent on social messaging apps as the mediator (Valkenburg & Peter, 2007; Dienlin & Johannes, 2020). Internet technology in the form of social media platforms creates a space for adolescents to orient themselves in a public social network: a digital version of social dynamics, status, and comparisons (Boyd, 2017). Social comparisons in social media can be detrimental to young adults' life satisfaction and well-being (Masur, 2021). On the other hand, exposure to these social dynamics through the accessible medium of social media allows adolescents to learn social skills and manage their interpersonal relationships effectively (Gross et al., 2002; Boyd, 2017).

Life Satisfaction and Subjective Well-being

Referring to Bronfenbrenner's model, Duncan found a reciprocal relationship between teacher well-being and student well-being, suggesting that student well-being outcomes can be examined by referencing the resources students have available to them (2025). These students, thus, experience different subjective well-being outcomes dependent on the environment; the contextual factors are nuanced and varied in measuring life satisfaction and subjective well-being (Duncan, 2025; Martinson & Berridge, 2014; Maddux, 2017). With contextual and environmental considerations in mind, well-being and life satisfaction may be key constructs related to social connectedness (Maddux, 2017). A person's idea of their own SWB (Subjective well-being) can vary, and how someone defines their values is not to be compared to another's definition (Maddux, 2017; Martinson & Berridge, 2014). The literature here recommends that

researchers approach life satisfaction and subjective well-being with an open mind and keep in mind the potential biases at play (Maddux, 2017).

The Satisfaction with Life scale is a commonly referenced and utilized scale to measure global life satisfaction levels, having a high internal consistency and high reliability on subjective well-being (Diener et al., 1985). Other ways of measuring subjective well-being include the conceptualization of "flourishing" as a way to understand "Eudaimonic" or purposeful being (Keyes, 2002; Stone, 2013). Eudaemonic well-being is negatively correlated with aging, and strengthening well-being relates to positive outcomes with physical and mental health (Ryff, 2018). These outcomes extend to broad populations, such as in the case of bolstering autonomy and friendliness in adolescents in school, as well as preventing mental illness and reducing psychological stress among older populations (Ryff, 2018). In the conversation of subjective well-being, varying Western and Eastern definitions of well-being need to be respected, an example being the concept of ikigai in Japan relating to purposeful life engagement (Maddux, 2017; Ryff, 2018). In the context of ageism, ableism, individualist ideology, and conservative stances on aging in the West, social connectedness as a factor for a healthy life needs to be examined (Maddux, 2017). In the United States, "successful aging" is medicalized through the Western lens, lacking considerations related to spirituality and cross-cultural values that factor into social connectedness (Martinson & Berridge, 2014). The western definition lacks the consideration of diverse cultural populations and various environmental factors, such as social well-being (Martinson & Berridge, 2014).

Key trends focus on the COVID-19 pandemic and its subsequent effects on psychological well-being. Sources utilized surveys as the main form of data collection during this time, which may lead to various biases as a result of their self-reporting nature. Sources reviewed also tend to

focus on technology in education, likely since research is largely conducted by professionals and students from academia. The literature suggests that the implications of modern technology on well-being are unclear and have many more contextual considerations; the dynamic is much more complex when measuring adolescents on various life satisfaction and well-being scales (Dienlin & Johannes, 2020; Wu et al., 2016; So et al, 2023).

The gaps in this area of research: due to the rapidly evolving nature of technology characterized by innovation and commercialization, research lags behind already implemented technology and products. Due to this rapid implementation, this study intentionally references sources from 2000-2010 to define how technology research compares to research in modern technology from 2010-2025 and onward. Recent developments in AI and chatbots have opened up enormous amounts of data for collection, analysis, and dissemination. Populations such as older folks or younger children are difficult to assess and qualitatively measure; the effects of technology arguably have the greatest impact on these populations.

It is important to consider the lasting impacts of evolving technology, and a key population that drives these changes is the young adults who have developed alongside it. These constructs, nuanced and important to consider for well-being and life satisfaction, lead to the current study and research question: To what extent do relationships through technology relate to levels of subjective life satisfaction among emerging adults?

Method

Participants

Participants (n = 7) were contacted. Participants self-identified a wide range of backgrounds: varying levels of technology use, locations on the west and east coast of the United States, and varying professional aspirations. Participant 1 is a white male, 24, located in

Washington, working as a water technician. Participant 2 is a Mexican-American male, 21, located in Orange County, currently studying to become a pilot. Participant 3 is a Korean-American female, 21, based in New York, studying sociology at NYU in pre-med. Participant 4 is a Pakistani-American male, 21, born and raised in New York, studying Integrated Design and Media at NYU. Participant 5 is a Chinese-American female, 19, raised in New Jersey, studying Integrated Design and Media at NYU. Participant 6 is a Chinese-American female, 21, born in Maine, based in New York, and studying Integrated Design and Media at NYU. Participant 7 is a Chinese-American non-binary, 22, who studied at Carnegie Mellon University, and is based in San Francisco, founding a software for creatives. Half of the interviews conducted were with NYU students, and the other half were conducted with non-NYU-affiliated individuals (see Table 1).

Procedure

7 participants were interviewed for this qualitative analysis study, collected using snowball sampling and convenience sampling methods. I asked friends to connect me with anyone willing to be interviewed for a paper about technology, social connection, and life satisfaction. I collected 3 participants willing to be interviewed over Zoom. I collected 4 participants in-person, 2 people from mutual friends, and 2 people from convenience sampling on the NYU campus: asking idle students if they would be interested in being interviewed for a university paper. Interview time ranged from 30 minutes to 90 minutes, with topics branching out into a variety of fields and topics. One group interview was conducted with Participants 5 & 6.

Interview Protocol

The semi-structured interview consisted of three main sections. Technology (Protocol A) consisted of questions related to use cases throughout the interviewee's day (e.g., How do you

use technology from the moment you wake up to the moment you go to bed?). Clarification was given that for this study, digital technology is defined as the use of digital content through phones, devices, or television. Social Connection (Protocol B) consisted of questions related to the participant's experience, definition, and desires in social relationships (e.g., How do you define a strong social network?). Participants were asked about ways in which they stayed connected through technology, and further questions were asked to discover each person's unique dynamic with technology use and social connection. Life Satisfaction and Subjective Well-being (Protocol C) referenced and built upon the Satisfaction with Life Scale items (Diener et al., 1985). This 5-item, 7-point Likert scale is a quantitative measure; Questions were evolved into a qualitative format for this study. By asking participants the reasons and conceptualizations behind their satisfaction with life ratings, this study effectively explores the relationships between these new dynamics in technology and well-being, supported by a widely used and respected measure for global life satisfaction (Diener et al., 1985). The procedure for the group Interview 5, with Participants 5 & 6, followed the standard protocol for each individual; however, more freedom with the interview structure was given. Both perspectives were given more discussion space in between questions to share and build upon each other's ideas (see Appendix A).

Coding Process

The coding for this study was developed using a grounded theory approach (Glaser & Strauss, 1999). A bottom-up approach was used, first utilizing open coding by identifying key themes and terms that participants used: creating broad themes. Then, comparisons between transcripts identified parallel or contrasting factors related to these themes; Identifying the relevant factors related to that theme created sub-themes. Through axial coding, these themes

emerged and created complexities related to emotional relevance and utility with these constructs. From emotion and utility, sub-themes emerged and diverged into codes. These constructs are nuanced, and themes, sub-themes, and codes imply that these nuanced dynamics are not simply “good” or “bad”. These constructs and participants’ perception of them vary considerably, as they relate to contextual factors, use cases, and emotion. Three major themes emerged: Technology as a Tool, Relationships built into Life Satisfaction, and Conflicts with adapting to AI. Inter-rated reliability does not apply, as there was only one researcher for this study and the coding process.

Results

Participants have varying backgrounds related to the internet, technology, and digital media use. These participants also utilize and conceptualize technology differently in their everyday lives. In this data, there was an overall perception about the ubiquity of technology and how it has a role in nearly every aspect of human life. Technology as a Tool emerged as the core theme from the data, with three subthemes emerging: Utility and Dependence, Habit-formation in Awareness of Time, and Contrasts between In-person and Digital Connection. A second theme emerged: participants reported that relationships were a major factor in their definition of Life Satisfaction. The last theme: participants reported controversies in adapting to AI technology (see Appendix B).

Technology as a Tool

Participants emphasized how technology can be used in a wide variety of contexts, and how technology is to be used as a tool. Participants defined technology in different contexts: examples such as the water faucet, printing press, social media apps, AI, and LLMs. Topics included software used in tech spaces, video game usage among adolescents, and AI use in a

wide range of contexts. The term “tool” was used to describe technology 9 times, emphasizing its functionality.

Utility and Dependence. In its wide use cases and applicability in modern life, participants mentioned technology helping them with daily life in addition to being too “reliant”. In this discussion of digital devices such as smartphones, participants mentioned the terms “essential” or “need” 14 times. A common thread between these needs was when navigating through the city or town, using devices as a GPS. Participants 2 and 5 mentioned:

I feel like first of all, being new to the city, I can't really navigate without GPS... I don't think I could function without it; I can't really navigate without it. So I feel like that's very essential.

Surrounding social media and social contexts, participants felt that technology was key to staying connected, yet technology also created issues with the feeling of anxiety and FOMO (Fear of Missing Out). In this sense, technology for staying connected was incredibly useful yet created a different set of issues; phones being needed or a part of participants’ daily lives created a sense of dependence. Participants 5 and 6 noted:

It would be inconvenient if I didn't have it... But over the long term, it will be your worst enemy; Technology is a tool... but then it also creates FOMO. It creates a lot of anxiety for people... but then it also creates community.

Habit-formation and Awareness of Time. Participants mentioned “scroll” or “scrolling” 13 times throughout the discussion of social media apps’ short-form content feature. The term “time” was mentioned 35 times, in the context of “screen time”, “waste time”, or “spending time”. References to “time” are often focused on the concept of loss: “losing time” to these apps led to reports of regret. Participants across the board mentioned that devices with social media

apps take away from their time and sense of time, through gradual habituation. Participants noted:

The algorithm of certain apps, specifically Instagram, is designed to trap you in there; I realized 90% of the time when I turn on my phone, it's just to feel it... It's become... like a water bottle... an emotional like buddy; I just, like, pull it out when you're bored, that's when, like, doom scrolling happens... when you're just spending idle time; I realized I... scroll. I get lost very, very fast.

Contrast between In-person and Digital Connection. Participants vocalized how technology is often used to connect with others through messaging apps and social media. Participants described "Face to face" and "In Person" 15 times: noting that in-person interaction was the goal in using these apps. "Text" or "Message" was noted 30 times, often described as a "means to an end" or a substitute for the "real thing".

It hinders our communication... when you're in a long-distance relationship... there's so much like body cues that you might not be able to see; You're trusting someone only based on their voice... Rather than, like, your mannerisms, the way you act, the way you dress in person.

Relationships built into Life Satisfaction

Participants described that a large portion of their definition of Life Satisfaction included building and maintaining meaningful relationships with others, such as family, friends, or partners. The term "friends" was mentioned 40 times, the term "Family", "Parents", or close relatives was mentioned 22 times, and the term "talk" and "conversation" was mentioned 28 times in the context of Life Satisfaction. Maintaining these relationships often included physical proximity and touch. Participants 5 and 1 mentioned:

The first time I felt a genuine hug in my life... came from my grandma... There was just something about it that made me want to cry... it is just so different; Meaningful social connections happen in person... Face-to-face, you actually have to, like, learn how to talk as a person.

In response to questions related to the Satisfaction with Life scale, participants noted a strong connection as part of their long-term values. Some participants described the length of familiarity with a person as an indicator of strong relationships, whereas others mentioned that length didn't matter. Participants also responded to the questions of an "ideal life" by describing their experiences:

My ideal life. I want to be able to give back as much as possible... help just people anywhere; I realized that I really like having people that I could always like talk to... having, like, good conversation and meaningful conversation; One of the biggest indicators [of a strong relationship] is the time I've spent with you... I've seen you grow... We can figure out any solutions... because in many cases, it feels like they're part of my family.

Participants described relationships with others as the foundation for "contentness" and "must-haves for life". Whether it be Participant 7's aspiration to "found" a software for artists, or Participant 5's deep appreciation for physical touch, each participant mentioned interaction with others as a long-term, sustainable source of satisfaction with life.

Conflicts with adapting to AI

When prompted about thoughts on AI, participants gave varied responses about the ethical implications of integrating AI into our technology use and society. The term "AI" was mentioned 28 times in the context of AI having a negative impact, and 20 times used in the

context of AI being a helpful collaborator in a positive context. Participants 6 and 1 mentioned the potential flaws about where AI currently stands in educational contexts:

I feel like people will get dumber as AI, like, advances... it's just spitting out information... There's only so much information you could feed to a model; I feel like people are becoming overly reliant on it... We're just gonna forget how to do things ourselves.

Participants mentioned that critical thinking skills and creativity were degrading in our modern age, referencing both the use of AI and the consumption of short-form content. Participant 5 described their personal use and how it has changed their cognitive ability:

I am not going to lie. I feel like I've been getting dumber since AI came out.

On the contrary, Participants 7, 3, and 2 mentioned how AI can be used positively. Utilized with a clear purpose or well-defined goals, AI can be used in ways that empower ingenuity. This pro-AI perspective contrasts with the former anti-AI perspective on the discussion of creativity. Participant 7 utilizes AI daily to help them with building software, and offers their perspective on the field of AI:

Creatives are very, very anti AI... instant backlash... But the people who are actually like making the models... they're making this because they genuinely want to make people's lives easier; I see... AI... as a collaborative tool for creativity.

Discussion

The purpose of this study was to identify the relationship between technology use, social connection, and subjective well-being. The aim was to explore these constructs and their dynamics to determine if the outcome of Life Satisfaction is relevant in this discussion. Our results concluded that this dynamic is nuanced: how someone approaches these tools, how they react to new technologies, and how relationships are maintained in these digital contexts are all

relevant in the analysis and response to our research question. The results identify that mindless use, social comparison, and fear of new technology are factors that indicate negative outcomes. Positive outcomes can be seen in participants who use technology with clarity, creativity, and awareness. This study identifies technology as a core tool used by people for the purposes of connecting socially, aligning with existing literature that identifies technology as a medium for social connection (Masur, 2021; Wulf, Breuer, & Schmitt, 2022).

These findings reinforce existing literature on social media use, recognizing its nuanced nature as a tool used to connect socially (Gross et al., 2002; Boyd, 2017). Participants mentioned that attention-grabbing content existed in the form of humorous, dangerous, or novel stimuli: aligning with existing literature on arousal and novelty in digital content (Bethel et al., 2025). For life satisfaction, this study aligns with existing research on life satisfaction correlating with connectedness and tight-knit relationships (Hadi, Hwang, & Shaffer, 2024).

These findings extend existing research by drawing connections between past literature and the modern constructs that have evolved. Moving out of the COVID-19 pandemic in 2019, participants mentioned that adapting to digital formats was no longer an issue in educational and commercial contexts (Gravelle et al., 2024; Van Deursen & Van Dijk, 2018). However, the reasons behind technology use remained: in response to fears of isolation or procrastination, users relied on technology and digital content for escapism (Wulf et al., 2022). This poignant observation is crucial for guiding future research into combating digital escapism. One construct in modern social media use is “doom-scrolling,” closely aligning with the user losing track of time. This study builds upon existing research on procrastination and avoidance by defining specific outcomes associated with poor social media use, as supported by Dienlin and Johannes (2020) and Wu et al. (2016). The foundation of “doomscrolling” is built on a sense of losing

track of time, extending the existing literature by defining the outcomes of social comparisons and short-form content use (Boyd, 2017; Masur, 2021). With this lost sense of time, new constructs and dynamics must be explored and established behind awareness and mindfulness as factors behind healthy social media use. This study establishes awareness and mindfulness as integral topics to explore with digital relationships, a gap in the current literature. This study highlights the vital importance of exploring the link between AI use and outcomes, using contemporary and relevant data on emerging adults. This study highlights the urgent need for research on psychological constructs that may be affected by AI use and implementation, given the rapid implementation of AI and significant gaps in AI research in the field of psychology. The literature on technology references lacks relevance in modern contexts, as it fails to consider the impact of digitization, including Large Language Model functions, digital commercialization of products, and AI use as a social partner (Kraut et al., 1998; Valkenburg, 2007).

These findings deviate from existing research on digital connectedness for life satisfaction. Hadi, Hwang, and Shaffer (2024) found that individuals with strong digital connections and close relationships reported higher life satisfaction than those who were more sociable but detached. Despite comparisons between four variables, research by Hadi, Hwang, and Shaffer (2024) reveals that digital connectedness is linked to higher reports of life satisfaction, contradicting many participants' views on technology and social connections.

This research study aimed to define the current state of relationships between humans and technology, with the aim of understanding and improving well-being. This study's reports have significant implications for research, as they can inform the exploration of the dynamic between in-person and digital connections. The factors identified in this study, including physical touch, social signifiers, and social media dynamics, can be applied to various research fields, such as

psychology, human-computer interaction, and touch medicine. This study's insights can also inform the development of future technologies, guiding innovations in robotics, immersive products, and experience design, and shedding light on how humans interact with technology. This study identifies emerging adults as the main population that has the greatest potential to guide technological change. This study is valuable for its focus on emerging adult populations, emerging technological changes, and discovering dynamics related to improving well-being. Limitations for this study include the population focus and the subjective well-being measure. Future directions should research further into diverse populations, not limited to students or emerging adults. Expanding the population focus can uncover insights related to broader technology use. To expand on this study, future directions should utilize objective well-being measures, building on these newly explored constructs through quantitative measures to lay the foundation for a wealth of future research. As we leverage evolving technologies, connect with others effectively, and strive to enhance well-being levels, research on these constructs becomes indispensable for a relevant and informed academia, a competitive and modern business, and impactful and meaningful organizations.

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Table 1

Demographic Characteristics of Participants

Participant	Age	Location	Major/Work	Screentime (Hours)
1	24	WA	Water Technician	5
2	21	CA	Aviation	8
3	21	NY	Sociology	4
4	21	NY	NYU IDM	4
5	19	NY	NYU IDM	2
6	20	NY	NYU IDM	8
7	22	CA	Software Founder	5

Appendix A

Interview Protocol

Greeting, Warmup, and Consent:

"Hello! Thank you for your time today. I'm interviewing you as part of my university coursework at NYU, and I'm particularly interested in how your experiences have led to where you are now. You can answer these questions or prompts in any way you'd like, and feel free to refrain or say "pass" when answering any questions you aren't comfortable with. You can choose to stop any time you would like to, and respond with whatever you feel is most appropriate or important to you! This interview will be recorded. Any questions before we begin?"

Demographics

"To start us off: What is your age, gender identity, and ethnicity?"

If a student: "Could you say a little bit about where you are right now, academically, and where you are working towards?"

If non-student: "Could you describe your professional background, and where you plan to work in the future?"

Protocol A - Technology

1. What kinds of digital technology do you use daily?
    a. How much time do you spend on these digital devices? (Ask participant for their screentime on phone, or a ballpark estimate if other devices are used)
    b. What is the majority of your time spent on when using technology?
    c. What are some general worries with technology that you or others have?
    d. What are some benefits of technology that you or others have found?

Protocol B - Social Relationships

2. Social Relationships
    a. Tell me about a time when you felt truly supported by a friend.
    b. How does the device/use of technology alter the feeling of the relationship?
    c. What moments in your life do you feel most “connected”?
    d. Please describe what a strong social connection looks like for you.

Protocol C - Life Satisfaction

3. Scale Questions
    a. "When you picture your 'ideal life', how does your current reality compare?"
    b. “What are some factors for a satisfied life for you?”
    c. "If you had to describe your overall contentment with life right now, how would you describe it?"
    d. "If given the opportunity to live your life over, what would you change and why?”

Closing

“Thank you for taking part in this interview. I always like to ask this question towards the end: Was there a question you felt you were going to be asked today, but weren’t? What question do you feel should have been asked about these topics today? What’s your answer to that?”

“Thank you for talking to me today. I’m going to stop the recording now.”

Appendix B

Description of Themes and Codes

Theme	Codes	Definitions	Examplar Quotes
Technology as a Tool	Utility	Functional, usable, and useful for daily life	"I feel like first of all, being new to the city, I can't really navigate without GPS... I don't think I could function without it; I can't really navigate without it. So I feel like that's very essential."
	Dependence	Not being able to live without, a core necessity	"It would be inconvenient if I didn't have it... But over the long term, it will be your worst enemy; Technology is a tool... but then it also creates FOMO. It creates a lot of anxiety for people... but then it also creates community."
	Habit Formation	Engaging with devices frequently, without aim or purpose, and out of compulsion	"The algorithm of certain apps, specifically Instagram, is designed to trap you in there; I realized 90% of the time when I turn on my phone, it's just to feel it... It's become... like a water bottle... an emotional like buddy."
	Lack of Awareness of Time	Losing track of time, forgoing responsibilities, forgetting tasks	"I just, like, pull it out when you're bored, that's when, like, doom scrolling happens... when you're just spending idle time; I realized I... scroll. I get lost very, very fast."
	Contrasts between In-person and Digital Connection	Non-verbal social cues, contextual clues, and accessibility	"It hinders our communication... when you're in a long-distance relationship... there's so much like body cues that you might not be able to see; You're trusting someone only based on their voice... Rather than, like, your mannerisms, the way you act, the way you dress in person.

Theme	Codes	Definitions	Example Quotes
Relationships within Life Satisfaction	Strong Relationships	Authenticity, reciprocal, warm	“The first time I felt a genuine hug in my life... came from my grandma... There was just something about it that made me want to cry... it is just so different.”
Conflicts with adapting to AI	Improving	Being useful, freeing up cognitive space, benefiting life	“Creatives are very, very anti AI... instant backlash... But the people who are actually like making the models... they're making this because they genuinely want to make people's lives easier; I see... AI... as a collaborative tool for creativity.”
	Degrading	Reducing creativity, intelligence, and ingenuity	“I feel like people will get dumber as AI, like, advances.” “I feel like people are becoming overly reliant on it... We're just gonna forget how to do things ourselves.” “Younger kids should not have access to AI. Not how kids should learn to grow up, because, like, they're gonna be dumb in college…would you really want that person to, like, be a doctor?”